

that no other place would give me more. Until I was finally able to reject the “either/or” options and find my radical middle of *both* fulfilling social justice work *and* reasonable compensation. I was able to increase my income by \$31,000 a year in a matter of three years. This was made possible by two job changes and earning my master’s degree within that time. Those decisions led me to finding an organization with practices that matched their ethos; they cared for all people, including their employees, and compensated us fairly. I didn’t have to leave the field I loved, I just needed to get creative with how I engaged in fulfilling work.

If your income isn’t covering the basics, you’re not going to be able to pursue any needs beyond physical and every financial move you make is going to feel stressful. So instead of viewing either earning more or living on less as better than the other, finding your radical middle and values-based spending can support you wherever you choose to land.

The four F’s are going to look different for everyone, but they are the baseline for figuring out what you love and where you want to spend your money. If you know what you want most is to be able to pick your kids up from school every day without being beholden to a 9 to 5 schedule, you will spend your time better (probably looking for a new job or starting your own business), you will spend your money better (saving to be able to quit), and you will make more strategic goals (like avoiding a brand-new car purchase or paying off debt to lower your monthly expenses). If you don’t know what you’re really after, then leaving your job just looks like one of the hundreds of good ideas that seem out of reach. And if it’s out of reach, might as well buy a latte every afternoon to reward yourself for dealing with your horrible boss who won’t let you pick your kids up! *So, before you think about the tangible things you love to buy, invest time in thinking about how to afford the things you want that money can’t buy.* Think about how much time you’d like to spend with your family and what kind of work schedule you need to do it. Think about how you’d like to show up as a partner, parent, and friend. And think about how you want to disconnect from the noise of the world and connect more intentionally to what’s significant. When you think about things like these, values-based spending isn’t just a way to save money or spend without guilt. It becomes your gateway to living a values-aligned life.